

HORS D'OEUVRES **DILIP BOBB**

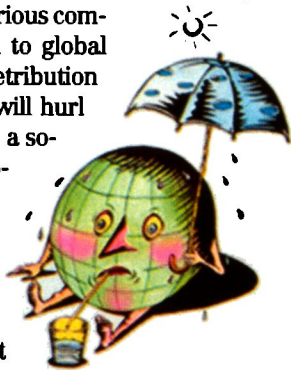
Perils of Eco-Anxiety



If the proliferation of diseases and afflictions to do with lifestyles wasn't enough to give you palpitations at night, here's one more. It's called eco-anxiety. Al Gore has no idea of the havoc he has wreaked upon an unsuspecting world. His heart-stopping warning in his documentary *An Inconvenient Truth* that only 10 years remain to avoid an environmental catastrophe has only added to the growing number of people worrying themselves sick over issues like global warming, pesticides in food, nuclear waste, vehicle emissions and carbon footprints. In fact, eco-anxiety has even created a new breed of professionals: eco-therapists who counsel patients on making environmentally friendly lifestyle changes. The fears of the eco-anxious are fuelled by excessive and often hysterical media coverage of doomsday scenarios like the one outlined by Gore. In fact, we have a new phrase to describe such coverage: climate porn! The word was created after the US-based Institute for Policy Research analysed hundreds of media articles, news clips and TV ads on the issue. Climate porn refers to the use of apocalyptic language to describe the challenges posed by climate change.

Pornography or not, what it has achieved is to give most people on the planet a serious complex about their contribution to global warming and the inevitable retribution that the environmental gods will hurl down on them from above. As a socially conscious citizen, my eco-anxiety has really changed a lot of things I took for granted. I work for a widely circulated weekly news-magazine that prints on paper made from trees cut down in a forest somewhere.

Am I committing a mortal sin each time I write? Should I petition the publisher to reduce the number of pages? It's a Catch-22 situation, similar to the feeling I get when I climb into my gas-guzzling car every morning. Shouldn't I be cycling to work instead? Actually, considering distance and time, that would mean waking up at 4 a.m. and getting home at 9 p.m. which is hardly conducive to good health and quality time at home. I also turn pale when I look at the greens sold by my local vegetable vendor. What foul pesticides have gone into their preservation and why do they look so unnaturally green, or yellow, or red? So, would it be better to reduce my living space and plant a vegetable garden even if it means sacrificing a much-loved and much used balcony? My best friend's apartment is on the 17th floor. Could I reduce electricity consumption by taking the stairs or would I be inviting a seizure? Going green and saving the planet is all very laudable but the anxiety is killing.



ANIL DAYAL

SOUGHT AFTER:
Cultivators in Punjab


Rooting for Farmers

CHANDIGARH The Lok Sabha polls are still a year away, but political parties are busy bolstering their pro-peasantry credentials—farmers are suddenly the new flavour of the season. In view of reports about the UPA's plans to announce a big-ticket package to resuscitate the ailing farming sector, opposition parties are rooting for the farmers' cause lest the Congress take the credit of being the sole benefactor of the farming community. The ruling Shiromani Akali Dal-BJP combine is

flexing its muscle to put up a show of strength at the Ramlila ground in Delhi while SAD President Sukhbir Singh will be demanding a Central debt waiver for farmers and a package for industries. Not to be outdone, Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda has written to the Centre demanding a Rs 500-crore package to compensate the farmers' loss of crop due to cold wave in north India. Clearly, hopes of a good political harvest have sprung from farmers' woes. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

Pleasure Pays

DELHI Males above 18 looking for some work have a new job opportunity—the post of a condom tester is up for grabs. UK-based condom manufacturer SSL International has announced plans to recruit testers for its Durex range of latex.

A two-year study by the Indian Council of Medical Research had found that condoms made according to international sizes were too large for a majority of Indian men.

Hence the drive by Durex. It has held such tests in other countries too including France, Germany, New Zealand and Malaysia.

The chosen 1,000 men would get a supply of select condoms and will have to provide their feedback to the company. If that is a lot of work for a harried or a married tester, at the end of project he will get a certificate endorsing his participation in the programme and earn the status of a good lover in the bargain. Too good to be true, eh? ■